Studying Up and Sideways: Situating Workers within Broader Labor Ecosystems

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Abstract

This SIG explores how CSCW researchers might broaden digital labor research beyond workers' experiences to examine the actors, infrastructures, and political-economic arrangements that produce extractive labor conditions. Drawing on traditions of "studying up," it asks how CSCW might study power upward toward capital and sideways across broader sociotechnical networks. Through this session, we aim to reflect on our positionality and identify new concepts, methods, and collaborations for understanding how extractive digital labor conditions are produced, maintained, and contested.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing → Collaborative and social computing**; **Human computer interaction (HCI)**.

Keywords

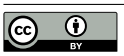
Labor, Worker, Studying Up

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1 Introduction & SIG Goal

CSCW and HCI has a long tradition of centering research on labour and technology. Notably, critical scholarship in the field has extensively documented how workplace technologies, ranging from AI and algorithmic management to automation, surveillance, and monitoring, entrench the power of capital and its associated web of actors and infrastructures while disciplining labour and weakening its power and bargaining position [16, 23]. Varied forms of worker resistance and collective actions generated by these deteriorating working conditions have also been discussed [11, 21, 24]. In these conversations, labour has rightly served as the primary analytic focus [7] for two key reasons: a) capitalism entails a set of social relations between labour and capital, and processes of capital accumulation cannot be separated from the labourers from whom surplus value is drawn [12, 13] and b) although workers are subject to structural power at the point of production [2, 3], they are not merely subjects of exploitation but transformative political agents, whose withdrawal potentially exposes the architecture of dependence that capital works to conceal. Contemporary approaches in digital labour research, [1] including worker inquiry, participatory action research, have built on this foundation, confronting power from labour's own standpoint and generating systematic knowledge from it [6, 28]. CSCW and HCI communities have also expanded their research agenda toward supporting labour in contesting and transcending existing work structures, through supporting and centering collective organization and political action, imagining alternative design futures, and building tools and knowledge in solidarity with workers [16, 22, 25].

Yet while we know a great deal about how workers experience and resist extractive conditions, greater analytical attention is needed to understand how and why such conditions are produced, maintained, and legitimated: through which sociotechnical arrangements, by which actors and institutional configurations, and in whose interests. There have been important, though still limited, attempts within CSCW and HCI to move in this direction, including work examining technology companies' imaginaries of the future of labour [4]. Further, macro-level explanatory tropes such as neoliberalism, capital accumulation, and financialization carry significant analytical power in tracing the widening circuits of capital operating at national and transnational scales, yet such accounts are often detached from the specificity of how exploitation is concretely



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[1] For more detailed discussion on digital labour or labour mediated by digital technologies, see [10].

organized and sustained.[2]. What is needed alongside these is research grounded in rich ethnographically-inspired empirical detail, capable of accounting for how specific actors — corporations, states, medias, platforms, venture capitalists, and their intermediaries — produce and sustain conditions of oppression and extraction. Drawing from social and anthropological research traditions, "studying up" [8, 15, 27] — a research orientation that has begun to attract attention in CSCW and HCI [1, 14, 26] — enables precisely this analytical focus, shifting scholarship beyond the "archives of oppression and victimhood" that have at times surfaced in labour research too: an exclusive preoccupation with the suffering and experiences of oppressed communities and exploited classes, rather than scrutiny of the powerful actors and institutions that produce these conditions in the first place [26].

In the absence of such a research agenda, digital labor scholarship in CSCW has been shaped by privileging workers as primary research participants — useful as this is — it also at times direct analytical attention toward incremental prospects of supporting workers through design, bound by short-term horizons, rather than building counter power against the structural entanglements, circuits, and networks that produce exploitation and harm. For example, recent CSCW work has critiqued the tendency to read algorithmic technologies and related worker precarity, such as in the gig economy, primarily as an information asymmetry problem, one resolvable through better transparency or design [24], rather than attending to how these conditions are produced through histories of coloniality, entanglements of capital, law, technology, institutional arrangements, supply chains, funding structures, and regulatory regimes, where choke points and prospects of resistance might be located within this broader ecology, and what role researchers and other actors in solidarity with labour's causes might play alongside workers themselves. Nonetheless, there are also few notable glimpses of differing research trajectory, such as the analyses of anti-unionisation technologies deployed by corporate platform companies [17], and examinations of the legal instruments through which digital labour classifications are manufactured and defended [5].

This SIG asks how CSCW might broaden its digital labour research agenda without displacing its commitment to workers through the following themes:

1.1 Theme 1: The Need for Methodological Innovation

Rather than looking only "downward" — toward workers, their experiences, consciousness, and resistance — **how do we also study upward toward capital, platforms, designers, and state actors, and laterally across the networks of intermediaries, investors, consultants, legal actors, and technical infrastructures that produce and sustain extractive labor conditions?** This is not merely an expansion of scope but a methodological reorientation: one that demands the same empirical and ethnographic rigor that worker-centered research has long modeled, directed now toward the actors and arrangements that have been examined largely indirectly through workers' experiences.

However, such a reorientation raises real analytical and methodological challenges that the field must confront honestly. Many of the arrangements that shape digital labor are structurally difficult to access: protected through non-disclosure agreements, official secrecy provisions, intellectual property claims, and the deliberate inaccessibility of key documents and decisions [19]. Even institutional research ethics boards — often wary of legal retaliation from powerful corporate actors — can discourage or constrain such lines of inquiry [9]. These obstacles are not incidental; they are themselves expressions of the power relations this research seeks to examine.

1.2 Theme 2: Contesting Conceptualizations of "the worker"

Workers are not a stable category. They are conceptualized differently across intellectual traditions: as proletarianized subjects within classical Marxism, as optimizing agents within neoclassical economics, and as "prosumers" within emerging accounts that blur the boundaries between production and consumption [18]. Attending to these shifting conceptualizations can help CSCW researchers examine how different analyses of workers lead to different diagnoses of power, dependency, and possibilities for intervention.

1.3 Theme 3: Reflexivity and Positionality

Studying up also opens onto uncomfortable questions of positionality: what it means to pursue this inquiry from within universities whose research programmes are increasingly funded by the very platforms and technology firms under scrutiny, and how researchers might develop ethical and political stances that preserve critical independence without foreclosing institutional possibility. These are not merely problems to be resolved in advance but tensions to be named, collectively negotiated, and built into the methodological fabric of this emerging research agenda.

1.4 Goals of the SIG

This SIG creates a space for CSCW researchers to collectively explore these questions and identify concrete next steps for future research. Its immediate purpose is to bring together CSCW researchers working across digital labour, critical data studies, platform power, and allied fields to collectively map what studying up and studying laterally in digital labour research might look like in practice — what methods it requires, what sites it opens, and what conceptual tools it demands. We aim to facilitate discussions for how CSCW researchers might study up, down, and sideways in digital labour research. This SIG will build a community interested in examining not only workers' experiences, but also the actors, infrastructures, and political-economic arrangements that produce extractive labour conditions. It will connect scholars across labour, political economy, platform studies, critical data studies, and related areas, while surfacing shared methodological and ethical challenges

[2] A central preoccupation of digital labour research has been not only documenting exploitation, including wage theft, precarity, and dispossession, but also identifying the technological, political, social, and cultural mechanisms that enable and normalize these conditions as ordinary features of the contemporary economy [10] Even so, beyond macro-level frameworks and theoretical approaches, there remain relatively few ethnographic studies that examine in depth how ruling elites, corporations, states, and other powerful actors profoundly shape the worlds of labour and structure the conditions under which workers live and labour. A recent work focuses on venture capitalists [20].

in studying power, capital, and upstream actors. This session welcomes CSCW researchers and practitioners interested in system design, power and counter-power, critical approaches to labour, and new concepts, methods, and collaborations for studying the broader arrangements that shape digital labour.

The larger ambition of the SIG is to seed a sustained research community: one committed to developing the empirical, ethnographic, and theoretical resources needed to examine not only how workers experience and resist extractive conditions, but how those conditions are produced, legitimated, and actively defended by corporations, platforms, states, and the wider networks of actors that have remained largely unscrutinized in CSCW. We take this to be both a scholarly and a political commitment: a recognition that understanding the architecture of extractive power, with the empirical rigor and critical independence it demands, is itself a contribution to the broader project of contesting it.

2 SIG Structure

We will hold the SIG session in-person at CSCW 2026. This session will involve interactive participation.

Time	Activity	Participation
0:00–0:15	Welcome and framing presentation on "Back to Labor," "studying up," and "revisiting studying up."	Organizers
0:15–0:45	Small-group discussion across three themes: *The Need for Methodological Innovation*, *Conceptualization and Theory*, *Positionality and Ethics*.	Organizers and participants
0:45–1:15	Group summaries and collective reflection on key insights, questions, and connections across themes.	Organizers and participants
1:15–1:30	Synthesis and discussion of future directions.	Organizers and participants

Table 1: Proposed SIG session schedule (90 minutes)

3 Organizers & Facilitators

Inha Cha is a PhD student at the Georgia Institute of Technology. Her research examines when, why, and how AI is adopted, refused, or deliberated in organizational settings, framing AI adoption as a key site where worker agency is formed and reshaped.

Ashique Ali Thuppilikkat is a PhD Candidate at the Faculty of Information, University of Toronto. His doctoral research explores the role of technology in worker resistance and unionization amid the platformization of urban life.

Yigang Qin is a PhD student in School of Information Studies at Syracuse University. His current research examines how political economic and cultural conditions precipitate the formation and changes of digital technologies in realms of production and social reproduction.

Richmond Y. Wong is an Assistant Professor of Digital Media at the Georgia Institute of Technology. He studies how social and organizational environments can support workers' ethical decision-making in the tech industry.

Priyank Chandra is an Assistant Professor in the Faculty of Information at the University of Toronto and director of STREET Lab. His research studies the resistance practices of communities at the margins of society and how these practices are mediated by technologies, with a focus on social movements and worker resistance

Eunjeong Cheon is an Assistant Professor at Syracuse University's School of Information Studies. Her ethnographic research examines how robots and AI reshape labor, attending to the broader configurations of actors and institutions that bring these technologies into work.

4 Technical requirements

Given the planned format of the meetup, we would need a quiet space with round tables to support small-group discussions. A screen and microphone would also be useful for introducing the meetup, displaying discussion prompts and facilitating the discussion.

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